

CHAPTER 4: FORGE WEAPONS. GAIN MAGIC.

Rhys took Catria, her family, and the other Terrian war mages to the arena to forge Catria's weapon.

Rhys was very happy that Aschelle wasn't there. That wasn't surprising as they had a larger group going on soul quests than the other cities.

Terrian was the first group to arrive, but only minutes later, team Cruia walked in.

"Sorry," Boran, the Cruian team captain apologized. "We didn't realize you were in here, or we would have waited."

Rhys met his eyes. "Normally, I wouldn't care if Cruia saw us forging, but this time is..."

"I know about Catria's unicorn," Erik admitted. He held up his unicorn hair. "I saw it too."

"We were together," Catria explained.

Since neither team really had to hide anything from the other, they both went to the fairy fire.

Catria went first. She threw her willow bark and leaf, her silver, and her unicorn hair into the blue flame. Then she placed her gem and hand on a special spot by the edge of the fire.

Catria's heart raced as the flames flew high up and swirled around. She really wasn't sure how much time it took, as she was very overwhelmed that she was about to be an official war mage.

The fire stopped swirling, and a staff appeared in the flames – A staff! She wasn't expecting a staff. She'd been training with a sword, as they were common weapons. Yet, perhaps there was a reason for the staff. She took it from the fire and the bracer her stone would go in and stared at them.

She put the stone in the bracer and put it on her arm. Then she swung the staff around. It felt good in her hands.

Everyone gathered around and congratulated her, but she suggested that they hold their celebrating and let Erik forge his weapon.

Erik put went over to the fairy fire and put his rowan, copper, and unicorn hair in the fire. He too held his gem and put his hand on the stone edging.

The flames swirled high, as they had for Catria, and the weapon that appeared in the fire was a white whip. A whip for his weapon didn't surprise Erik, but he hadn't seen one so white before.

He took it and his bracer and stepped down from the

platform. After some congratulations, he too tried out his whip. It felt really good in his hands. Definitely it didn't strike like a regular whip.

"We should go," Erik suggested, motioning over to show the Phyrnian team was coming in.

Both Terrian and Cruia left quickly, heading out an exit on the opposite end of where the team from Phyrn was coming in.

They left the arena but didn't go back to their cities. There was a war mage complex by the arena. There was common area in the center and a wing for each city's team going off of it.

Both teams Cruia and Terrian went to a restaurant in the middle of the building to eat, as it had been a long day.

They each filled their plates and sat down. Rhys has many questions for Dillion, the captain of Cruia. After all, they didn't have to fight often, and Terrian did all the time.

Catria didn't worry about them. Erik came and sat beside her. He began the conversation with, "That was quite the adventure."

"It was," Erik agreed. "But you did amazingly well."

"I'd have died without you," she pointed out.

"No, you'd have died without the unicorn," Erik corrected.

"I needed you more than that," she countered with a

rosy blush.

Erik met her eyes. “If you ever need me for anything else, let me know. I’m good with a staff. If you want some training, I’m happy to help you.”

“Is that allowed? Catria asked. “We could end up fighting each other. I wouldn’t think you’d want to help me.”

“Of course I do,” he assured her. “First, if ever we fight in the arena, I will not hurt you. Second, you are more likely to fight Aschelle or Phyrn. Cruia doesn’t attack, and Terrian never attacks Cruia, so I think I’m safe from you.” He put his hand on her arm and looked in her eyes. “This is serious,” he explained. “Other team’s war mages will fight to kill you, especially if they find out you have unicorn. I want to help you.” He chuckled. “Besides, it gives me a change to see you again. Honestly, I want to call on you.”

Catria’s eyes went wide. “You do? When?”

Erik shrugged. “Whenever you are free? Personally, I’m free tonight. Would you like to go on a walk after dinner.”

“I’d love to,” Catria answered. “But Rhys may want me to practice to see what I can do with my staff.”

“I’m sure Dillion will want to see what my whip does too,” Erik agreed. “But at the same time, he’ll likely understand waiting because I want to take time with you.”

“Rhys likely is a little more strict,” Catria countered. “But if I can, I will. I’ll also check with him. If he lets you help me, I’d be glad for it.”

They didn’t make it out on a walk. Instead, a girl ran into the room. She was obviously Phyrnian, but not as large as most of them. She ran over to Rhys and Dillion and pleaded, “Help me! Help me! I need asylum.”

“Hold on,” Rhys urged. “Explain.”

The girl blew out a breath to calm herself. “I am Xena, from the Cold Blood tribe. My father has arranged a marriage to Slayde and they forced me to go on a soul quest. I don’t want to be a war mage, and I don’t want to marry Slayde. He’s looked up to because he’s a war mage, but I want out of the Phyrnian culture. I see how Terrian is. I want it.”

“Hold on,” Rhys instructed. “I can’t grant asylum. The king will have to do that, but I will try to help. I need answers first. Let’s start with why you don’t have your weapon and what items you have.”

“I didn’t forge my weapon,” Xena explained. “I did eat a leaf, so I do have enhanced strength and healing, but I ran away as my team was going into the arena.”

“Stop right there,” Rhys insisted. “They will come looking for you here soon. Let’s go to the Terrian wing and hide you while we talked.”

He didn’t just go with her, the entire Terrian team, plus team Cruia went too.

The bedroom they went into was crowded, and Rhys sent Hrod out in the hall to watch for trouble.

He then continued, “What are your items?”

“It doesn’t matter,” Xena answered. “I’m not forging a weapon. I’m not becoming a war mage. Supposedly, it’s an honor, but I’d rather live a normal life. I can be helpful to you. I am very good with a bow and arrow. I can hunt about anything.”

Dillion interjected. “You still haven’t answered what your items are.”

Xena pulled out her items. She had several macadamia nuts, several leaves, and bark from the tree. Her animal was a white tiger hair. Tiger was common, but white tiger was rare. “I pulled it from its tail,” Xena explained. “I wasn’t about to try to fight one. I found it asleep, pulled a small hair, and ran.” She then showed that her stone was lodestone and that the metal she brought it was iron.

“Wow!” Catria exclaimed. “Those are strong items. With them, you could likely control metal.”

Xena shrugged. “That’s what Slayde told me to. He’s eager to get me on the team. Once I am, then he’s going to marry me. My father arranged it.”

“Are all marriages arranged in your tribe?” Rhys asked.

“No,” Xena answered. “They aren’t, but my father wants the prestige of me marrying a war mage and the

money he will get from Slayde as a dowry.”

Catria’s eyes went wide. “He’s selling you?”

Xena shrugged. “Please, let me have asylum here.” She suddenly stiffened. “If you give me asylum, will I be forced to marry or be sold into slavery?”

Rhys laughed. “No, we aren’t like Phyrn.”

Xena cried. “I know. That’s why I ran away. I don’t want to be a war mage, and I don’t want to be forced to marry a horrible man. He’s already...” She broke down crying uncontrollably.

Rhys put his hand on her arm. “We’ll take care of you. We can get you to the king and request asylum. You will have to swear an oath of loyalty, and you will have to follow our laws. Likely, you will be under some supervision to make sure you assimilate before given total freedom.”

“That’s fine,” Xena agreed.

Dillion then countered, “Or, she could come to Cruia. I do have the authority to grant her asylum, and I do. Rhys, Terrian will be the first place suspected of hiding her. People really don’t think much about Cruia, and since we mostly stay out of the fighting, we aren’t the first place they will look.”

Xena looked over at Dillion. “What’s life like in Cruia, and how will I be treated?”

“You won’t be forced to marry,” Dillion assured her. “It will be pretty much like Terrian, but instead of having

a guard assigned to watch you until you've shown you can integrate, we'll put you working on a farm. You'll be paid, of course, and whoever runs the farm will report if you commit crimes."

Rhys looked over at Dillion. "Aren't you worried she could hurt the people whose farm you put her on?"

Dillion chuckled. "Cruians are pretty tough. We work hard, so there aren't very many weaklings in our city. Cruia is the biggest city too as far as land goes, so if we put her down on a southern farm, even if Phyrnians come to look for her, they won't likely find her."

Xena jumped at the offer. "It sounds like I'll be able to hunt and grow a garden. Phyrnians mostly live off meat, but I have a small garden. I love it." She stopped and shuddered before she admitted. "My parents hated it, said it made us look weak, and destroyed it. In Cruia, I can garden!"

"Yes," Dillion assured her. "In fact, we have many people who can teach you how. There are plenty of wild animals in the southern part of the city to hunt too." He then leaned closer to her. "I will asked that you give me your items. I will keep them in a box in case there is reason that you should forge your weapon, but I don't want you sneaking off and forging one without us knowing."

She gladly handed her items over and stated, "Deal! When do we leave for Cruia?"

"Tomorrow," Dillion answered. He then stopped, his

face turning to a very contemplative expression, then suggested, “Rhys, would you allow us to stay at your headquarters tonight? We can’t get to Cruia tonight, and I don’t think it’s safe to stay here. Soon team Phyrn will come looking for Xena.”

“Sure,” Rhys approved. “Let’s go. Everyone, we’re headed home. Let’s hope no one sees Xena with us. If so, we’re in for big trouble.”